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12/9/25

Period 3

Allen

Author Study (Mary Shelley)

Early Life

Mary Wollstonecraft Godwin or more known as Mary Shelley, was born in London, United Kingdom on August 30, 1797. She was born William Godwin, a radical philosopher, and Mary Wollstonecraft, a feminist writer, who died from puerperal fever 11 days after giving birth to Mary. From infancy, Mary was in company of many friends of her father like the poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge and Charles Lamb. Godwin felt unfit to raise his daughter alone so, when Mary was 4, her father married Mary Jane Clairmont, who had two kids of her own, Charles and Jane and later had a half sister, Franny Imlay. Mary didn't get along with her stepmother, who was jealous of her stepdaughter, which made her feel detached from the family especially once her younger brother, William, was born. As she grew into adolescence she studied her mother's writing, which immersed her into her parents' political beliefs and "became aware that society frowned on those who espoused such views." (Huntley)

Adult Life

In the meantime, an admirer of her father, Percy Shelley, visited him and briefly met Mary at age 14. Percy Shelley was 22 years old, married, and expecting his second child when he and Mary felt attraction for each other 2 years later after their initial meeting. One month before Mary turned 17 years, both of them eloped to the continent and for the following year traveled places like Switzerland, Germany, and Italy. They faced financial difficulties as Percy's father cut off Percy's allowance after his elopement and not only that 2 years later in 1816, Mary's half

sister, Fanny, and Percy's wife, Harriet, committed suicide. Mary and Percy married in London and tried gaining custody of the two children by Harriet but were denied. Later they tried having children of their own, yet three of the children she had died in infancy which made Mary fall into a deep depression which only dispelled after giving birth to the only surviving child, Percy Florence. Her marriage also suffered too as Percy formed romantic relationships with other women while she was still grieving the loss of their children.

Major Works the Author Is Known For

In the span of her life, Mary wrote 7 books, 2 travel narratives, 23 short stories, 3 children stories and much more works. But out of all her works, she is very well known for her book, *Frankenstein, or the Modern Prometheus*, a Gothic novel that is about a scientist who brings life to a sentient creature through an unorthodox scientific experiment. It centers around many themes like the consequences of playing God and the dangers of unchecked scientific exploration. She was inspired by two 1816 events, “a ghost-story-writing contest and a discussion of the possibility of employing electricity to “galvanize a manufactured humanoid” (Huntley). There are 3 versions of this book with the first edition having 3 volumes and the 2nd edition having 2 volumes. The book is widely considered “one of the first science-fiction novels and a Gothic horror classic” (“Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley”) ; it has had a lasting impact on English literature and storytelling since people still read and cherish the book. 164

Historic Period

Mary Shelley was born in the late 1700s and lived between early to mid 1800s, a time when the Industrial Revolution and major political changes were changing England. She spent her youth during the Romantic period, which emphasized emotion, nature, and reaction to industrialization. Her works such as *Frankenstein* and *The Last man* reflect the era's interest with

science since it was still the enlightenment era. Shelley's writing was also influenced from an early age, as she was born into a household surrounded by literature and radical thinkers, including her parents, who held progressive views that differed from societies. Additionally, Mary's literary works stepped into a gothic tradition, being characterized by the exploration of human emotions and moral ambiguity.

Time Period Reflected In Work

Throughout Mary Shelley's writing, there was a significant event not only for Mary but many other writers during the era that influenced the theme of their works. It was the 1815 eruption of Mount Tambora or also known in English literature the "haunted summer" ("Mary Wollstonecraft Shelley"). It made the following year in Switzerland feel unusually cold, dark, and stormy. In January 1816, Mary alongside with her husband went and stayed at a popular mansion for writers in Cologny, and the owner Lord Byron, a poet, challenged his guests to a "ghost story contest" ("Mary Wollstone craft Shelley"), which proved to be the genesis idea for Mary's soon-to-be masterpiece, *Frankenstein*. Furthermore, her novels provide a "modern twist to traditional gothic elements by focusing on psychological rather than supernatural phenomena." ("Mary Shelley"). Outside of her writing, Mary lived in a period when women had limited educational and professional opportunities, which contributed to her decision to publish *Frankenstein* anonymously upon its initial release. 161

Excerpt From *Frankenstein: Or the Modern Prometheus*

Chapter 16

"Cursed, cursed creator! Why did I live? Why, in that instant, did I not extinguish the spark of existence which you had so wantonly bestowed? I know not; despair had not yet taken possession

of me; my feelings were those of rage and revenge. I could with pleasure have destroyed the cottage and its inhabitants, and have glutted myself with their shrieks and misery.

"When night came, I quitted my retreat, and wandered in the wood; and now, no longer restrained by the fear of discovery, I gave vent to my anguish in fearful howlings. I was like a wild beast that had broken the toils; destroying the objects that obstructed me, and ranging through the wood with a stag-like swiftness. O! what a miserable night I passed! the cold stars shone in mockery, and the bare trees waved their branches above me: now and then the sweet voice of a bird burst forth amidst the universal stillness. All, save I, were at rest or in enjoyment: I, like the arch-fiend, bore a hell within me; and, finding myself unsympathised with, wished to tear up the trees, spread havoc and destruction around me, and then to have sat down and enjoyed the ruin.

"But this was a luxury of sensation that could not endure; I became fatigued with excess of bodily exertion, and sank on the damp grass in the sick impotence of despair. There was none among the myriads of men that existed who would pity or assist me; and should I feel kindness towards my enemies? No: from that moment I declared everlasting war against the species, and, more than all, against him who had formed me, and sent me forth to this insupportable misery.

"The sun rose; I heard the voices of men, and knew that it was impossible to return to my retreat during that day. Accordingly I hid myself in some thick underwood, determining to devote the ensuing hours to reflection on my situation.

"The pleasant sunshine, and the pure air of day, restored me to some degree of tranquillity; and when I considered what had passed at the cottage, I could not help believing that I had been too hasty in my conclusions."

Literary Analysis

In Mary Shelley's novel, *Frankenstein: Or the Modern Prometheus*, the author argues that social rejection creates evil through the creature's suffering and isolation. Using imagery and frame narrative, Shelley reveals the creature's emotional destruction after his rejection by the De Lacey family. This moment shows that his violence is a result of social cruelty rather than being born evil. The passage reflects on aspects of Shelley's life, especially about alienation and emotional neglect.

One of the best ways Shelley develops her theme is through imagery as we feel the despair the creature is feeling after being rejected by the De Lacey family. From the start of chapter 16 it states, "Cursed, cursed creator! Why did I live? Why, in that instant, did I not extinguish the spark of existence which you had so wantonly bestowed?" As he wanders alone through the woods, he describes giving a "vent to my anguish in fearful howlings" and compares himself to "a wild beast that had broken the toils." With this imagery, it emphasizes how social rejection strips the creature of his humanity and forces him to be the "monster" he was destined to be. By portraying the creature's emotional pain through images of isolation and savagery, it lets the reader empathize with him and lets Shelley vent out the same isolation she felt after she ran away with a man. While the isolation didn't make her an evil person, she still felt sadness in having no one be by her side and suffer alone all the misfortune she faced.

Furthermore, another thing that makes the novel stand out and work really well is the frame narrative Shelley uses that gives the creature a voice that can emphasize his separation from society. The story is being said by the creator before it can actually be read by the reader which creates a layer of different views that highlights the social rejection the creature experiences. For

example, after reflecting on the cottage incident, he observes, “The pleasant sunshine, and the pure air of day, restored me to some degree of tranquillity; and when I considered what had passed at the cottage, I could not help believing that I had been too hasty in my conclusions.”

This reflection demonstrates how the creature’s actions are a recounted experience, not being told during the present which emphasizes both his isolation and the way his story is interpreted through others. Often or not, many stories are just recaps of truth events that often lead to misinterpretation like Shelley’s decisions in not claiming ownership of the book when it first came out.

In conclusion, Mary Shelley uses many literary devices such as imagery and frame narrative to convey the destructive effect of social rejection on the creature. We the readers can emphasize and image the pain and rage as well understand him and his actions throughout the story.

Overall, it shows that the creature’s violence is a product of neglect and isolation by others rather than being born evil.

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